

different way. Instead of driving to the mall, she started taking her food to a nearby park where she read a book.

“There was one day, after doing this for a couple of months, when I was just sitting at the park, reading my book, I looked up and I felt a lot of peace. I remember thinking, I can’t believe I used to go up to the mall every single day.” Your spending habits may seem complex, but if you take some time to break them down, you’ll find many of them just require a little creative tweaking to change.

Remember that spending as a result of any of these triggers isn’t bad. But your brain loves efficiency, and it’s creating habits whether you’re aware of it or not. The more you allow these triggers to dictate your spending, the more you let them establish habits you probably wouldn’t choose intentionally. When you’re aware of the triggers, you take back control of what spending habits you practice.

Shopping as an Activity

Some people think society could benefit from experiencing boredom more often. Doing less would definitely save you more money.

We are not those people.

We love doing stuff.

Being bored is for boring people.

Just kidding, but our mission statement is literally “If it’s not fun, it’s not Frugal Friends,” and we’ve been trying to convince you that frugality is fun since the first paragraph of this book!

Because we live by the principle of fun, we see and understand everyone who, like us, shops for fun. If you’ve ever hung out with friends at the farmer’s market, strolled the shops downtown before your dinner date, or walked the aisles of the thrift store “just to browse,” you are our people.

My childhood in the late ’90s and early 2000s was defined by this. Every weekend my mom would take me to some kind of mall, big box store, or street event lined with local vendors. I can’t recall my parents having hobbies. Shopping was our hobby. And we did it like it was a form of entertainment. When I wasn’t out shopping, I was at home devouring the Alloy and dELiA*s catalogs, circling everything I wanted but that my parents would ultimately never buy me. A girl could dream!